

The Woodland Studio school prospectus 2025

Dear students, parents and carers, I want to extend a warm welcome to all those bright young students and caregivers who are considering joining our democratic and child-centred community this year! We've just recently celebrated our 10th anniversary here at the Woodland Studio school which we're immensely proud to have achieved!

I want this prospectus to illustrate our school message, founded in the tenets of radical education. We centre education around the child and encourage their creative agency to flourish. Play and learning are intrinsically tied, and we see them as interconnected parts of education within our school (Wallerstedt and Pramling, 2012). We take great inspiration from radical democratic schools such as Summerhill and Sudbury, trusting our children deeply and believing the lessons they freely choose to take will lead them onto endless possibilities and a lifelong love for learning (Neill, 1968).

As the name suggests, the Woodland Studio school bases its pedagogical praxis within the forest school movement and eco activism, combining this with its creative sentiments in the indoor and outdoor studios. We encourage children to look after our school environment which in turn means they know how to look after the planet. We believe in building ecocapabilities, where children's wellbeing can be fostered through development of outdoor skills, understanding how to combat climate change through activism projects (Walshe et al., 2023, Tannock, 2021).

If this collaborative family sounds like a place where your child could thrive, then read on to learn much more about our philosophy!

What makes the Woodland studio school so radical?

The Woodland Studio school is a radical alternative to mainstream school. The phrase radicalism means 'to the root', and we believe this school values education and learning at its core, facilitating spaces where every child can play and have a voice. However, this radical route we've taken has caused some concern regarding the legitimacy of our practices, with the government constantly questioning whether a democratic, child-centred and play-based learning approach is ideologically dangerous for children (Sukarieh & Tannock, 2016). As Illich (1973) argues, this demonstrates a long-standing tension between mainstream and radical schooling, as the approach strays from the state controlled national curriculum and rejects standardised testing for measurable outcomes. We believe mainstream schools implement the hidden curriculum, where undercurrents of respect for authority and emphasis on conformity are taught (Apple, 2004; Neill, 1968). In response our students, who are part of a democratic community where no one voice is regarded superior to the other, have criticality and are exposed to a variety of engaging lessons.

Play is often seen as a foundational source of development in children (Vygotsky, 1967), and yet its importance within most mainstream schools in England is diluted once a child starts school (Clements and Harding, 2023). As Froebel (1886), the founder of the kindergarten discusses, there is a strong interconnectedness between play, nature and the child. Therefore, we embrace our natural surroundings and use them in school life. McMillian, known for her vision of the 'open air' nursery, reflected Froebel's sentiments of a nature-based childhood, stating that children should play outdoors often, develop motor skills and eat well to prosper (Liebovich, 2019). We believe these practices create an engaged pedagogy through a love of learning. This is because fear of authority is absolved and replaced with mutual care and critical awareness (hooks, 1994).

In our philosophy, we share our creative items by way of tools, materials and ideas which assists every learner (hooks, 1994). This sharing of common goods also creates a common motivation for community support and a democratic understanding, respecting everyone's ideas as equally valuable (Fielding, 2007). We take inspiration from Bloom's (1948) ideology, where children must feel that they count, are wanted and can make a worthwhile contribution to the school community. We mirror Tolstoy (Tolstoy, Pinch and Armstrong, 1982)

and his radical schooling methods, creating a school which feels alive and is constantly transforming. Children evolve in mind, through grasping new concepts every day, and body through developing motor skills when playing in the woodlands (Dabaja, 2022). The school does this through children's autonomous access to continuous provision activities, choosing their lessons and learning materials, facilitating a child's agency and right to choose subjects that interest them (Bryce-Clegg, 2025) Below is a quote from one of our teachers regarding how they feel working in our radical school:

“ Since joining the school community 5 years ago I’ve found the learning experience so much broader for both students and staff. In comparison to my old school where students felt rushed and closed off from teachers, and we as staff felt stressed and lost the meaning of teaching, the Woodland Studio school offers an intensely positive learning environment to teach in where every single person is heard and understood.”

While these school principles explain why we are so radical, the following section displays how these values are demonstrated and what the students' learning experiences are like.

Our key philosophies

Building upon our radical foundations, our key philosophies in the Woodland Studio school centre around children having creative agency and show how we demonstrate democracy whilst harnessing play and nature. To us, creative agency means children can produce work such as art, designs, projects and writing whenever they'd like (Beauregard, Papazian-Zohrabian and Rousseau, 2024). There is a philosophy of playfulness which underpins how children learn, reflecting the Froebelian notion of play as a natural learning medium (McNair and Powell, 2021). While play and freedom are important, we acknowledge that self-directed schooling will not be suitable for all children, such as those who need more structure (Gray & Chanoff, 1986). However, through Freire's (2017) praxis regarding critical pedagogy and liberation through education, we see that facilitation of a child's agency can allow many to face oppressive power structures by accessing a critical consciousness. Through reflection and activism within the Woodland Studio schools' democratic meetings, staff and students will be able to solve issues when given responsibility.

The school also rejects the banking model of education, as Freire (2017) discusses, where teachers impose ideas upon children who must absorb it passively. Instead, through this play pedagogy teachers act as co-learners in a child's education, understanding what a student would like to see in education and facilitating this. Often in education we dismiss play as something we do after work has ceased and trivialise it as a break time activity (Parker, Thomsen and Berry, 2022). However, in the Woodland Studio school, play is a central foundation, allowing children to engage with learning in a way that interests them and frees them from the 'necrophiliac' control over their body through obsession with obedience and the suppression of creativity in favour of academic rigour that most children in mainstream school are subject to (Freire, 2017). A core philosophy this school holds is the recognition of children as full humans and therefore capable of asserting their ideas and their right to be heard.

Below is a quote from a student who has been with us for a year after recently transitioning from a mainstream secondary school:

“ At my old school I felt lost in the crowd, and it felt scary to challenge a teacher's ideas. Now I feel like I'm part of the school family and if I have a problem or idea I think is worth sharing there's no barrier preventing me ”

Creative agency within the Woodland Studio school can also hold political meaning. hooks (1994) theorised that education should focus on creating self-actualised human beings who could dismantle conformist notions and stand up to figures of authority. An example of creative and communal practice as a means for social change and political expression in our school is radical puppetry, where large scale puppets are made using recycled materials the children find (Bell, 2023). This allows students to become aware of themes of war,

capitalism and oppression and act this out in creative ways to solidify their understandings of the issues (Bell, 2023).

However, for politicised practices and agency to work well students need to have access to the opportunities we provide in our school. Issues of privilege become an obstacle as radical school may inadvertently reproduce class inequalities by charging a fee and being unable to take in lower income families (Fielding and Moss, 2010). To address this issue, our school uses a cooperative model of parent governance, where families can contribute to the school by performing tasks for the school such as painting, laundry and building in lieu of direct monetary compensation. We also have centralised budgeting as inspired by Gandin and Apple's (2002) research into participatory budgeting in Brazil, where a centralised pot of funding is in place for the school to purchase necessary resources.

Our school emphasises eco activism, strengthened by the need for our staff and students to care for their own woodland environment at school. We do this by exposing children to issues of global warming and the social injustice that comes with the climate breakdown worldwide (World health organisation, 2023). Here, the curriculum and sustainable form of forest schooling is directly resistance to Petro-pedagogies, where fossil fuel companies infiltrate schools through development of an

“oil- industry sponsored curriculum” (Tannock, 2020, p.479). Discerned by Tannock (2020), schools were susceptible targets in which to easily advertise fossil fuel use by an industry sponsored party towards a large population of accepting school children whose conceptions surrounding the environment were still emerging. Our school seeks to resist this form of biased education by employing Harts (1992) ladder of participation, showing the varying level of children's involvement in decision making, to increase student participation in climate activism via student led projects, student led public protests, dramatic enactments addressing ecological issues and solutions to reducing fossil fuels with published blog posts and articles made by the student body (Dunlop et al., 2021).

In this way, not only are children experiencing cross curricular learning, through geography and science, but also harnessing climate consciousness and subverting underestimations of how much change children are able to make (Tannock, 2021). Students were recently inspired by Greta Thunberg, who in 2018 at the age of fifteen became an eco-activist and a voice for resistance to world leaders' complicity in causing climate change through production of fossil fuels, amongst other elements (Tannock, 2021). Our students are inspired by global youth leadership and the change this can make to the environment, understanding that their voices matter in collective eco activism.

What might your child be doing in an average school day?

Morning

At our school, no two days are the same and every child experiences the day differently. A typical day begins at 9am after the children have eaten breakfast. It starts with a whole school morning meeting in the forest to ensure a constant sense of democratic participatory governance of both teachers and children (Gandin and Apple, 2002). Children may co-design the day's learning as well as having a timetable of activities they wish to participate in, constructed themselves at the beginning of term, as inspired by Summerhill school (Smith, 2008). We take elements from the forest school movement including extended outdoor risky play in any weather (Coates and Pimlott-Wilson, 2019). Activities include imaginative play out in nature, climbing trees and studying plants through drawing or nature journals. Drawing on Freinet (1995) students engage in living biology and living geography, observing insects and plants and keeping a weather diary. They even participate in cultivating and harvesting produce grown in the school's large kitchen garden, where they come to understand the importance of keeping the environment healthy. We want our school to be accessible for disabled students, with research displaying that parents fears of the risks and the perceived vulnerability of disabled children in an outdoor setting may be barriers to participation (Von Benzon, 2011). We have placed board walks for children to access the woodlands who are in wheelchairs and have accessible play equipment, built with the help of the parent cooperative who supplied some building materials and assembled the apparatus.

Afternoon

In the afternoon, lunch is held communally, reflecting bell hooks' view that education

should be a space to “ build community in order to create a climate of openness ” (hooks, 1994, p.40). After eating, students can continue their morning exploration in one for the schools' indoor studios, making edits to their work and adding new ideas in a process of reflection to solidify their understanding (Watling and Clarke, 1995).

Students can move fluidly between spaces and collaborate with peers based on their self-designed timetable, resisting the immobilisation of mainstream schools and confinement to 'necrophiliac' classrooms Freire (2017) critiques. In this way, even very young children can explore their agency, allowed the freedom to plan, shape and reflect upon their own learning (Watling and Clarke, 1995). School becomes a living, breathing, flexible organism (Tolstoy, 1982) and one which heralds a collective, shared learning space of mutual care for children.

The woodland studio schools governance is comprised of a balanced voice of teachers and students in weekly meetings who decide major changes and bring up any points to debate, such as behavioural issues (Smith, 2008; Tolstoy, Pinch and Armstrong, 1982). Recently a few children put forward a suggestion to make the school more modern by asking for computers in the studios, so they were able to learn how to code and design digital art (Resnick and Robinson, 2018). We all voted and almost everyone agreed it was an excellent idea, and so within 2 weeks we had acquired 15 new computers, some donated by parents and some bought second-hand with our communal spending pot. Through this dialogue a slow pedagogy was asserted (Clark, 2022), whereby everyone is listened to intently and deeply, where no point is too small to dismiss or too complex to debate. In this way everybody's time is valued, thoughts are reflected upon and then developed into actionable strategies for change.

In our school there is no formal assessment in the earlier years, and opportunities for older students to take exams such as GCSE's or A -Levels if they choose. Instead of standardised exams, portfolios will be created by the students, displaying the body of work they have achieved throughout their school experience and presented when they leave (Holt, 1976). Inspired by Freinet's concept of community zines and a shared printing press for the school, students and teachers collaborate to showcase the material produced by our school in weekly newsletters (Carlin and Clendenin, 2019). Additionally, school exhibitions are designed to allow children to display their work and feel proud of their discoveries (Toft and Shepard, 2022).

How does our school compare to other models of radical schools around the world?

You may have heard of some other radical schools in the country and around the world. Our school has taken inspiration from democratic schools like Summerhill in England and Sudbury in the USA. While our school borrows some key philosophies from these systems, we also differ greatly on some foundational points.

Like Summerhill, we value personal freedom, democratic governance of co learners and the view that young people can shape their own education (Neill, 1968). We both use meetings and voting systems to create rules and improvements for the school so that no child feels inferior to any adult. However, we diverge from Summerhill's complete free choice structure and its micro community which doesn't participate in the wider world. Instead, we work with the community around us as one way of promoting eco awareness. We draw upon Chatelier and Van Dermijnsbrugge's (2022) advocacy for 'structured anarchy', whereby the school emphasises freedom as supported by negotiated routines and boundaries. In this way we differ from Summerhill's approach to complete freedom, placing the forest as a place of play and learning simultaneously.

Moreover, the Sudbury system of schooling advocates for radical freedom and democracy with little structure, believing children must have complete self-guided learning (Gray and Chanoff, 1986). Akin to the Sudbury school, here rules are not imposed by staff arbitrarily but are negotiated with students (Wilson, 2015). We agree with the notion that children should have their agency facilitated but we differ to the Sudbury system in a few ways. Sudbury rejects any type of curriculum and student collaboration on projects, but we draw upon the praxis of Freintian inquiry cycles of critical action learning (CAL) (Pantazidis and Moisiadou, 2025), where active decision making, intentional dialogue and critical reflection take place between all school members to address challenges. This strategy also means that less confident speakers may feel more comfortable if they feel their voice is valued. We also reject the idea that within Sudbury many of the conversations are completely child led and individualised, meaning adults are sometimes not able to act as co-learners at all. We believe that when our staff support discussion and have an equal voice to children, ideas develop more imaginatively (Neill, 1968).

By taking some ideas from both Summerhill and Sudbury, as well as many other radical school systems, we can provide a sustainable level of freedom for children and advocate for both autonomous individual learners and community collaboration too. This means the Woodland Studio school is highly democratic but is distinct in its mission to emphasis ecological awareness, creativity and social engagement outside of the school.

A note to end on

At the woodland studio school, eco activism, play and creative agency are central philosophies. By allowing children the freedom to play, they come to learn in unconstrained ways by having the space to confidently grow. We never underestimate a child who follows their creative passions and navigates their own paths of curiosity.

Our committed relationship to eco activism means that children learn to take care of their environment and understand the intricacies of our interconnected world. Through exploring their woodland environment through collaborative projects and hands on experiences, we believe the children have the tools to challenge ideas and embrace change.

Building the school hasn't come without its difficulties, but we believe this illustrates that the challenges facing radical education are not barriers but areas of opportunity to deepen the democratic, community rooted atmosphere of the school through discussion. This means that every teacher, child and parent can feel valued here.

We hope this prospectus has given you an insight into the daily lives of the students who attend. If you feel your child would benefit from inclusion in our community and the freedom to find out what they're most interested in, then we'd love to welcome you!

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